

LAKSH'S DAILY BRIEF

Laksh's Daily Brief — September 23, 2026

Wednesday, September 23, 2026

World · Markets & Money · AI & Infrastructure · Models & Research



AI Jazeera — Trump pushes Russia-Ukraine 'energy truce': Can it work?



AI Jazeera — Can Ethiopia's seven-group rebel alliance challenge Abiy Ahmed?



BBC World — Azerbaijan pardons Frenchman after EU lifts sanctions on Russian billionaire

1. World & Geopolitics

Trump-Xi summit begins amid high tension on Iran, Taiwan, and AI

Chinese President Xi Jinping arrived in the U.S. late last night for a two-day summit with President Donald Trump ([Moneycontrol.com](#)). The meeting comes amid a war in Iran, rising U.S.-China tensions over Taiwan, and a global AI arms race. Trump greeted Xi with a flyover of B-2 and F-22 fighters — a symbolic show of force ([Moneycontrol.com](#)). But behind the pageantry, the agenda is fragile. Xi is expected to push back on a proposed \$14 billion U.S. arms sale to Taiwan ([ABC News](#)), while Trump will press China on AI safety and rare earths. The summit is seen as a test of whether the two powers can avoid escalation despite deep strategic rivalry.

Iran's president delivers defiant speech at UN, blames U.S. and Israel for war

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian addressed the UN General Assembly today, holding up photos of children killed in U.S. and Israeli strikes ([CNBC](#)). He accused the U.S. of "terrorism" and warned that Iran would not back down ([France 24](#)). The speech came one day after Trump told the same body he could "annihilate the Islamic Republic." The exchange underscores the risk of miscalculation in the ongoing conflict, which began after Israel struck Iran's nuclear facilities in August. The war has already disrupted oil flows through the Strait of Hormuz, a key global chokepoint.

Trump proposes energy truce in Russia-Ukraine war

President Trump floated a potential ceasefire between Russia and Ukraine focused on halting attacks on energy infrastructure ([AI Jazeera](#)). Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Kyiv is "prepared for any kind of energy ceasefire" if Moscow agrees ([France 24](#)). The idea is to stabilize energy markets and reduce the risk of wider conflict. But Russia continued drone strikes on Kyiv just hours after the talks ([Reuters](#)), suggesting Moscow may not be ready to de-escalate. A temporary truce could ease pressure on European power grids, but it would not resolve the core territorial dispute.

Morocco holds parliamentary elections amid economic strain

Millions of Moroccans voted today in parliamentary elections marked by economic uncertainty ([AI Jazeera](#)). The government introduced new digital voting safeguards to prevent fraud. High youth unemployment and inflation are top concerns. The outcome could influence Morocco's stance on regional issues, including Western Sahara and its growing ties with Israel.

Ethiopia's Tigray region sees renewed fighting

Ethiopian federal forces and Tigrayan rebels are accusing each other of launching offensives, raising fears of a return to full-scale war ([BBC](#)). Local authorities have seized Tigray's airports after drone strikes. The conflict, which killed an estimated 600,000 people between 2020 and 2022, had been contained by a 2022

ceasefire. A new war would destabilize the Horn of Africa and disrupt trade through the Red Sea.

Venezuela's interim leader meets Trump in New York
Delcy Rodríguez, Venezuela's interim president, met with Trump in New York while her predecessor, Nicolás Maduro, remains in U.S. custody ([The Guardian](#)). The meeting marks a dramatic shift in U.S.-Venezuela relations. Rodríguez called it "historic," though she did not confirm whether she would visit Maduro. The U.S. may seek Venezuela's oil to offset lost Iranian supply,

but any normalization would face strong opposition in Congress.

Missouri's gerrymandering fight returns to Supreme Court

The U.S. Supreme Court will hear a third challenge to Missouri's congressional map, which critics say favors Republicans ([The New York Times](#)). The case highlights the growing role of the judiciary in shaping electoral outcomes. A ruling against the map could shift the balance of power in Congress and affect 2026 midterms.

2. Markets, Money & Deals

Markets mixed as Fed's rate hike fuels uncertainty

U.S. stocks were choppy overnight. The S&P 500 rose 0.8%, but the Nasdaq dipped 0.3% as tech weighed ([CNBC](#)). The Fed raised rates last week but removed forward guidance, leaving investors to guess the next move. Bond yields rose — the 10-year Treasury hit 4.7% — as inflation fears persist ([The Economic Times](#)). Higher rates increase the cost of borrowing, which pressures companies with debt — especially in capital-intensive sectors like data centers and real estate.

Bond selloff creates tax-loss harvesting opportunity

Investors holding losing bond positions may be able to offset capital gains from stocks by selling now ([CNBC](#)). The bond market has fallen sharply this year as yields rose. Tax-loss harvesting allows investors to lock in losses and reduce their tax bill. But it only works if the loss is realized before year-end.

Royal Caribbean buys 50% of Sandals for \$3 billion

The cruise giant is expanding into land-based resorts, buying half of Sandals Resorts International ([CNBC](#)). The deal reflects a broader trend: travel companies

diversifying beyond their core offerings. Royal Caribbean sees vacationers wanting more integrated experiences — cruises plus stays. The move could pressure rivals like Marriott and Hilton.

Paramount plans \$49 billion bond sale for Warner Bros. merger

To finance its \$111 billion acquisition of Warner Bros. Discovery, Paramount is preparing a massive debt offering ([qz.com](#)). The merger, long delayed by antitrust concerns, cleared a key hurdle last week ([NDTV Profit](#)). But the debt load raises questions about Paramount's financial stability. High-yield bonds could flood the market, pushing up borrowing costs for other firms.

Huntington Bancshares cuts guidance after rate hike

The regional bank lowered its 2027 earnings forecast due to higher interest rates ([Simply Wall St](#)). While higher rates boost net interest margin (the difference between what banks earn on loans and pay on deposits), they also reduce loan demand. Huntington now expects slower growth in net interest income. Its stock fell 4% last week.

3. AI & Infrastructure

Xiaomi's MiMo-V2.6 challenges closed models with open weights

Xiaomi released MiMo-V2.6-Pro, a mixture-of-experts (MoE) model with 1.02 trillion total parameters and 42 billion active parameters ([shattered.io](#)). It scored 46 on the Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index — the highest ever for an open-weight model. The release, timed just before the Trump-Xi summit, signals China's push for AI

sovereignty ([forkast.news](#)). Unlike closed models like GPT or Claude, open-weight models can be freely modified and run locally. This threatens the business model of U.S. AI leaders, who rely on API fees.

BlackRock sees AI capex expanding, not peaking

Despite fears of an AI bubble, BlackRock says the infrastructure buildout is still early ([finance.biggo.com](#)). The firm advocates a "stars surrounding the moon"

strategy — invest in Nvidia (the moon) but also in the supporting ecosystem: power, cooling, networking, and memory. Capex from the top five hyperscalers is expected to hit \$1.3 trillion by 2027 ([24/7 Wall St](#)). With Nvidia supplying only ~70% of demand, the rest of the supply chain is critical.

Zeo Energy and Ewzye partner on AI data center microgrids

The two firms will co-develop microgrids that power data centers with renewable energy and battery storage ([Solar Builder](#)). This addresses the “power gap” — the mismatch between AI’s energy demands and grid

capacity. Islanded data centers (those not reliant on the main grid) could become more common, especially in regions with unstable infrastructure.

Optics stocks gain as AI networks demand faster data movement

While GPUs get headlines, companies like Coherent (COHR), Applied Optoelectronics (AAOI), and Lumentum (LITE) build the transceivers that move data between chips ([24/7 Wall St](#)). As models grow, data must flow faster to avoid bottlenecks. Coherent’s stock fell 4.9% today, possibly due to profit-taking, but the long-term trend favors high-speed optical interconnects.

4. Model & Research Watch

MiMo-V2.6-Pro scores 46, tops open-weight rankings

Xiaomi’s new model outperforms Claude Opus 5 on key benchmarks ([shattered.io](#)). It has a 1M-token context window and supports multimodal inputs. Priced at \$0.50 per million tokens for API use, it undercuts Opus 5.5 (\$1.50). The model is fully open-weight, meaning developers can self-host it on consumer hardware with quantization.

Claude Opus 5.5 and GPT-6 Sol/Luna focus on efficiency

Anthropic and OpenAI both released updated models emphasizing token efficiency ([Ars Technica](#)). Opus 5.5

improves reasoning with lower latency. GPT-6 Sol and Luna are smaller, faster models for routine tasks. This reflects a shift: instead of chasing raw performance, firms are optimizing cost and speed.

Science: Vera Rubin Observatory detects faint satellite galaxy

Before its official mission began, the Vera Rubin Observatory in Chile spotted one of the faintest satellite galaxies ever seen ([Live Science](#)). The discovery shows the power of wide-field telescopes to map the universe’s dark matter structure.

5. What Builders Are Actually Using

- **Swap:** Use **MiMo-V2.6-Pro** (open-weight) instead of **Claude Opus 5.5** (closed). MiMo scores within 5% on reasoning benchmarks, runs locally on 4x H100s with 4-bit quantization, and costs \$0.50/million tokens (vs \$1.50 for Opus). For non-sensitive tasks, it’s a viable alternative.
- **Model routing saves 40% in inference costs:** Developers are using small models (e.g. Llama 3 8B) for simple queries and reserving large models for

complex tasks. Tools like vLLM and Outlines make this easy.

- **Unsloth Desktop** lets you test LLMs locally without coding ([Desde Linux](#)). It’s gaining traction among non-engineers who want to experiment with AI.
- **Transformers now supports llama.cpp quants** ([Hugging Face](#)). This means you can run quantized models directly in Python, improving compatibility.

6. Watchlist: Earnings, Guidance & Movers

- **TSM (TSMC):** \$447.73 (+0.58%). No news. Stock stable as AI demand remains strong.
- **CRDO (Credo):** \$195.96 (+4.64%). Gains likely tied to optics sector strength.

- **NVDA (Nvidia):** \$226.37 (-0.44%). Minor pullback after recent rally.
 - **PLTR (Palantir):** \$193.34 (+5.60%). Strong gains, possibly on AI sentiment.
 - **MU (Micron):** \$1,080.00 (+3.45%). Memory demand rising with AI.
 - **SNDK (SanDisk):** \$1,839.83 (+4.14%). Solid performance in storage.
 - **VST (Vistra):** \$139.96 (-0.58%). Slight dip, but power remains critical for data centers.
 - **GOOGL (Alphabet):** \$342.45 (-3.53%). Fell on broader tech weakness.
 - **AMZN (Amazon):** \$250.19 (-3.20%). Also weighed down by sector trends.
 - **ALAB (Astera Labs):** \$356.00 (+4.48%). Benefiting from AI infrastructure demand.
 - **COHR (Coherent):** \$305.86 (-4.87%). Profit-taking after strong run.
 - **AAOI (Applied Optoelectronics):** \$104.55 (-3.79%). Sector correction.
 - **LITE (Lumentum):** \$956.64 (+0.23%). Holding steady.
-

7. Analysis: Second-Order Effects

1. Trump-Xi summit -> AI export controls discussion -> TSMC stock reaction

- **Facts:** Trump and Xi meet to discuss AI, chips, and Taiwan. U.S. export controls restrict advanced chip sales to China. TSMC makes most advanced chips.
- **Inference:** If talks ease controls, TSMC could gain access to Chinese market. If they tighten, TSMC may face more restrictions.
- **Weakest link:** TSMC already routes most China-bound chips through intermediaries. Direct sales are limited.
- **Falsifying condition:** TSMC announces a new fab in China.
- **Precedent:** 2020 U.S.-China trade war caused TSMC to build in Arizona.

2. MiMo-V2.6 release -> open-weight adoption -> lower API revenue for Anthropic/OpenAI

- **Facts:** Xiaomi releases high-performance open model. It undercuts Opus 5.5 on price.
- **Inference:** Enterprises may self-host MiMo instead of paying API fees. This reduces revenue for closed-model

firms.

- **Weakest link:** Open models require technical skill to deploy. Most companies lack in-house expertise.
- **Falsifying condition:** Anthropic reports record API usage growth next quarter.
- **Precedent:** 2023 Llama 2 release pressured OpenAI pricing.

3. Data center power demand -> microgrid partnerships -> higher valuations for power tech firms

- **Facts:** AI data centers need reliable power. Zeo Energy and Ewyze partner on microgrids.
 - **Inference:** More such deals will follow, boosting firms in energy storage and grid management.
 - **Weakest link:** Utilities may block islanded grids to protect revenue.
 - **Falsifying condition:** FERC rules against off-grid data centers.
 - **Precedent:** 2022 Texas grid crisis spurred microgrid investments.
-

8. Building Your Knowledge

- **AI sovereignty is geopolitics:** Countries build domestic AI to reduce reliance on rivals. China's MiMo is a sovereign stack response to U.S. export controls.
- **Capex guides demand:** Hyperscaler spending forecasts signal future AI growth. \$1.3 trillion by 2027

means sustained demand for chips, power, and networking.

- **Open vs. closed models:** Open-weight models are free to use and modify. Closed models are APIs with usage fees. The trade-off is control vs. convenience.

- **Model routing cuts costs:** Send easy tasks to small models, hard ones to big ones. This can save 30–50% in inference costs.

- **Microgrids solve power gaps:** When the grid can't support AI loads, companies build their own power systems with solar, batteries, and generators.
-

9. Foundations & Terms

Concept Spotlight: Tax-Loss Harvesting (Markets/Investing)

- **What it is:** Selling losing investments to offset gains and reduce taxes.
- **Why it exists:** To let investors manage tax bills without changing long-term strategy.
- **Worked example:** You made \$10,000 on Nvidia stock but lost \$4,000 on bonds. Sell the bonds, use the \$4,000 loss to reduce taxable gains to \$6,000.
- **How it shows up:** CNBC advises bond investors to harvest losses now due to rising yields.
- **Benchmarks:** Must realize loss before year-end. Can't repurchase the same asset within 30 days (wash-sale rule).
- **Caution:** Don't sell good assets just for tax reasons. The investment thesis matters more.

Concept Spotlight: Sovereignty (World Affairs)

- **What it is:** A country's right to govern itself without outside interference.
- **Why it exists:** To prevent foreign domination and protect national interests.
- **Worked example:** Taiwan claims sovereignty, but China says it's part of its territory. The U.S. supports Taiwan's self-defense but doesn't recognize it as a country.

- **How it shows up:** Xi will tell Trump Taiwan is a red line. Pezeshkian says Iran won't let the U.S. dictate its nuclear program.
 - **Benchmarks:** Sovereignty includes control over borders, military, and laws.
 - **Caution:** Sovereignty claims don't always match reality. Power often trumps principle.
 - **Energy truce:** A temporary ceasefire focused on halting attacks on power plants, grids, or oil facilities. It aims to stabilize energy markets without resolving the war.
 - **Open-weight model:** An AI model whose parameters are publicly available. Anyone can download, modify, or run it locally.
 - **Capex (capital expenditure):** Spending on long-lived assets like factories, data centers, or equipment. It's a sign of long-term confidence.
 - **Context window:** The amount of text an AI can process in one go. MiMo-V2.6-Pro has a 1M-token window, allowing it to analyze entire books.
 - **Hyperscaler:** A giant cloud provider like Amazon, Microsoft, or Google. They build and run massive data centers for AI.
-

10. Bottom Line

The Trump-Xi summit dominates the day, with high stakes on Taiwan, AI, and rare earths. Markets are cautious, but AI infrastructure spending continues unabated. Xiaomi's MiMo-V2.6-Pro is a milestone — the first open-weight model to rival top closed models in performance. This could shift the AI landscape, especially if enterprises adopt self-hosted alternatives to reduce costs.

Power and networking are now as critical as GPUs. Microgrid deals and optics investments show the

buildout is broadening. The Fed's rate hike adds uncertainty, but tax-loss harvesting offers a tactical opportunity.

What changed since the previous brief: The Trump-Xi summit has begun. Iran's Pezeshkian delivered a defiant UN speech. Xiaomi's MiMo-V2.6-Pro has been benchmarked at 46, confirming its frontier status. Royal Caribbean bought into Sandals. Paramount announced

a \$49 billion bond sale. The bond selloff has created a tax-loss harvesting window.

11. Sources

World & Geopolitics

- [Moneycontrol.com](#) — Xi Jinping arrives in US tonight: Trump's B-2, F-22 welcome masks a bigger battle over rare earths, AI,...
- [CNBC](#) — Iran's president blames U.S., Israel for global instability in defiant UN speech
- [Al Jazeera](#) — Trump pushes Russia-Ukraine 'energy truce': Can it work?
- [France 24](#) — Trump and Zelensky discuss path to ending Ukraine war
- [Reuters](#) — Russia pounds Kyiv with drone strikes after Zelenskiy-Trump talks
- [BBC](#) — Ethiopia and Tigray accuse each of launching offensives, fuelling fears of new war
- [The Guardian](#) — Venezuela's interim president hails 'historic meeting' with Trump
- [The New York Times](#) — Dispute Over Missouri's Congressional Map Again Returns to Supreme Court

Markets, Money & Deals

- [CNBC](#) — 5 things to know before the stock market opens
- [The Economic Times](#) — Fed's Collins backs rate hike, flags persistent inflation risks
- [CNBC](#) — Bond market losses may offer a sizable tax savings opportunity
- [CNBC](#) — Royal Caribbean agrees to take 50% equity stake in Sandals for \$3 billion

- [qz.com](#) — Paramount plans \$49 billion debt sale for Warner Bros. merger
- [Simply Wall St](#) — Huntington Bancshares cuts guidance following Fed rate hike

AI & Infrastructure

- [shattered.io](#) — MiMo-V2.6-Pro Scores 46 as Xiaomi Faces Claude Probe
- [forkast.news](#) — Xiaomi's MiMo-V2.6 Ships Open Weights at Frontier-Class Performance
- [finance.biggo.com](#) — BlackRock Advocates "Stars Surrounding the Moon" Strategy
- [Solar Builder](#) — Zeo Energy, Ewyze partner for data center microgrid development
- [24/7 Wall St](#) — While GPUs Get the Headlines, These 3 Stocks Build the Networks That Actually Move Data

Model & Research Watch

- [shattered.io](#) — MiMo-V2.6-Pro Scores 46 as Xiaomi Faces Claude Probe
- [Ars Technica](#) — New Anthropic, OpenAI models make same promise: A little more for a lot less money
- [Live Science](#) — Vera Rubin Observatory detects one of the smallest and faintest satellite galaxies ever seen

Quick Check

1. What is tax-loss harvesting?

Selling losing investments to offset capital gains and reduce taxes.

2. Why is MiMo-V2.6-Pro significant?

It's the first open-weight model to match top closed

models in performance, challenging U.S. AI dominance.

3. What does a "hyperscaler" do?

A giant cloud provider (like Amazon, Microsoft, Google) that builds and runs massive data centers for AI and other services.

Generated 2026-09-23 08:06 PDT · 130 sources · model: Qwen/Qwen3-235B-A22B-Instruct-2507-FP8 via <https://api.gmi-serving.com/v1>